

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Judge rejects Trump’s mass firings



Federal workers demonstrate Feb. 14 outside the Health and Human Services Department. **MARK SCHIEFELBEIN/AP**

Administration told to rehire thousands of probationary staff

By Janie Har
Associated Press

SAN FRANCISCO — A federal judge in San Francisco ordered President Donald Trump’s administration to rehire thousands, if not tens of thousands, of probationary workers let go in mass firings across multiple agencies, blasting the White House’s tactics Thursday as he slowed the new president’s dramatic downsizing of the federal government.

U.S. District Judge William Alsup said that the terminations were directed by the Office of Personnel Management and its acting director, Charles Ezell, who lacked the authority to do so. The administration immediately filed an appeal of the injunction with the 9th Circuit Court. White House press secretary Karoline Leavitt earlier pushed back, casting the ruling as an attempt to encroach on executive power to hire and fire employees.

“The Trump Administration will immediately fight back against this absurd and unconstitutional order,” she said. Alsup’s order tells the departments of Veterans Affairs, Agriculture, Defense, Energy, the Interior and the Treasury to immediately offer job reinstatement to employees terminated on or about Feb. 13 and 14. He also directed the departments to report back within seven days with a list of probationary employees and an explanation of

how the agencies complied with his order as to each person. The temporary restraining order came in a lawsuit filed by a coalition of labor unions and organizations as the Republican administration moves to downsize the federal workforce. “These mass-firings of federal workers were not just an attack on government agencies and their ability to function, they were also a direct assault on public lands, wildlife and the rule of law,” said Erik Molvar, executive director of West-

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AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The sweet spell of success

Beatriz Whitford-Rodriguez, left, 13, of Skinner North Classical School, reacts after winning the 2025 Citywide Spelling Bee Championship, alongside Kwame Boateng, of McDade Classical School, at Curie Metropolitan High School in Chicago on Thursday. The winner will move on to the 100th Scripps National Spelling Bee in May in Washington, D.C., where they will compete in a field of 200-plus students. For more than 60 years, CPS has sent a regional winner to the National Spelling Bee.

Academics sound the alarm over crackdowns

Decry ‘viewpoint discrimination’ as protesters targeted

By Zareen Syed
Chicago Tribune

As President Donald Trump’s executive orders pave the way for the government to crack down on campus activism, including an order to deport international students who participated in pro-Palestinian protests, Madalin, an international doctoral student at Northwestern University said she’s keeping a watchful eye on the “horrors” being enacted by the administration. Madalin spoke to the Tribune on the condition that it would not disclose her full name as she wrestles with the fear of deportation. “It took me some time to realize the (implications),” she said. “Soon I started to sit with the idea that this could actually be a very substantial material problem for me. I have a partner here; I have a life here.” Madalin, originally from Italy, was hesitant to divulge the extent of her role in last year’s pro-Palestinian protests at Northwestern, one of 60 universities under federal scrutiny for what the Trump administration calls “antisemitic discrimination and harassment.” Recent events have reinforced her sense of caution. On Saturday, federal immigration authorities arrested

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Lilly Lerer tosses a flower into the Columbia Basin during an event marking the 100th anniversary of the Scopes trial near the Clarence Darrow Bridge on Thursday. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

On centennial of the Scopes trial, Chicagoans honor Clarence Darrow

Event lauds lawyer, activist at Jackson Park bridge named for him

By Carolyn Stein
Chicago Tribune

Nina Helstein has been celebrating the memory of lawyer and Hyde Park resident Clarence Darrow with other Chicagoans nearly every March 13 at a bridge named after him in Jackson Park since she was a young girl. “We come, rain or shine, whatever the day is,” Helstein said while holding a yellow daffodil in her hand. “I have stood under umbrellas, and sometimes it’s very cold.” But this year, Helstein — now 81 — got to enjoy the

mid-March event in warm weather with blue skies, joining other attendees in reflecting on the words of the famed lawyer and activist, his dedication toward fighting for free speech and labor unions, and how his fight rings true today for many. The event to honor Darrow’s memory has been held every March 13 at the bridge since 1957, almost 20 years after Darrow’s death. Typically, a wreath is thrown into the Jackson Park Lagoon that’s just behind the Museum of Science and Industry, but in more recent years attendees

have thrown flowers into the lagoon, as they did Thursday. The Chicago-based lawyer led the charge in multiple high-profile cases. Darrow defended teenagers Nathan Leopold and Richard Loeb in their 1924 murder case, successfully ensuring that his clients would not receive the death penalty for killing Bobby Franks. Darrow was also a prominent defender of labor unions, representing union leader Eugene Debs during the 1894 Pullman strike, when the Pullman Co.’s workers were

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‘The end of an era’ as prosecutor steps down

Bhachu was known for bringing corruption, mob cases in federal post

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

Ailing Chicago mobster Frank “The German” Schweih’s was all scowls in June 2018 when he was pushed into a federal courtroom in a wheelchair for a hearing in his racketeering case and two young federal prosecutors he’d never seen before were staring back at him. The feared Outfit hit man first barked a homophobic remark at one of them, Markus Funk, and said, “You makin’ eyes at me?” Then Schweih’s glared at Assistant U.S. Attorney Amarjeet Bhachu, who is Sikh and wears a turban. “What are we, in some kind of foreign country?” he cracked to his lawyer loud enough for the entire courtroom to hear. If Bhachu was taken aback by the comment, he didn’t show it, Funk recalled in an interview this week. He kept his arms crossed and remained expressionless, and the hearing went forward without missing a beat. “Schweih’s was trying to get under Amar’s skin and got no reaction at all,” Funk told the Tribune. The long-forgotten episode may have been a blip in one of the biggest organized crime prosecu-

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INSIDE



CHRIS SWEDA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Center of revamped Bears offensive line

The Bears addressed a major problem area in a big way by signing Drew Dalman, who was widely considered the top center on the free-agent market. Now they have to make it work. **Chicago Sports**

Tearing back ‘artifice’

Elvis Costello brings an early St. Patrick’s Day to a nontraditional show at the Park West. **A+E**

TODAY’S WEATHER

High **75**
Low **58**



Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 12

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